YouTube Content Monitoring — Billing Update

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We're asking to link a Google Cloud billing account so we can turn on automated monitoring for YouTube content violations on our class-recording channel. The monitoring itself will not cost anything at our scale — the billing account is a setup requirement Google imposes on the underlying service, not a sign we're buying something. This document explains the problem it solves, exactly what's being linked, and the real cost picture.

The problem

We recently found, by manually checking YouTube Studio, that 5 of our class recordings already carry copyright claims — 2 fully blocked, others blocked in specific countries. Nobody had noticed until someone happened to look.

We confirmed directly, by querying YouTube's own systems, that this is not a gap in our software — it's a platform limitation. YouTube does not expose copyright-claim status through the channel/API access it gives ordinary creators. A blocked video looks completely normal through every automated check available to us. The only two ways to find out are: someone manually opens YouTube Studio and looks, or someone reads the notification email YouTube already sends to the channel's inbox.

Without a fix, this repeats indefinitely: recordings can silently become unwatchable for students, for an unknown length of time, with no alert to anyone.

What we're proposing

YouTube already emails the channel's Google account whenever it places a claim on a video. Nobody currently reads that inbox for this purpose.

We're proposing to have our own systems watch that inbox automatically, using two of Google's own tools working together:

- **Gmail API** — lets an approved application see when new mail arrives in a specific inbox.
- **Cloud Pub/Sub** — the messaging service Google requires as the delivery mechanism for that "new mail arrived" signal.

The moment a claim notification lands, our system reads its subject and sender (not the body of unrelated personal email) and logs it for review — closing the exact gap that let 5 videos sit blocked, unnoticed, until someone happened to look.

Why a billing account needs to be linked

Google requires every Cloud project to have an active billing account — a payment method on file — before it will allow use of Cloud Pub/Sub, even for organizations that never end up being charged. This is Google's own gatekeeping rule, applied uniformly to every customer at every scale, not a signal about the size or nature of what we're building.

We'd attach this to the same Google Cloud project we already use for our YouTube integration — no new account, no new vendor relationship, one additional payment method on file.

Cost impact

Expected cost: $0/month, based on current published Google pricing (checked 2026-09-24).

Service	Our expected usage	Free allowance	Margin
Gmail API	A few relevant emails/week, plus routine inbox traffic	No charge for standard use; quota far above what one inbox generates	Not a realistic constraint
Cloud Pub/Sub	A few hundred tiny notification messages/month	10 GiB of message data/month, free	We'd need roughly 1,000–3,000× our expected volume to leave this tier

One honest caveat: Google has stated it plans to introduce billing for Gmail API usage that exceeds its quota limits later in 2026, with at least 90 days' notice before that takes effect, and has not yet published a price. Our usage is nowhere near that quota, so this doesn't change today's $0 estimate — it's disclosed here so it's never a surprise later, not because we expect it to matter.

Safeguards

- **Budget alert**: we'll set a low-dollar spending alert (e.g. $5/month) on the billing account itself, so anyone would be notified immediately if usage ever moved toward a real charge — well before it happened.
- **No new infrastructure spend**: notifications route directly to servers we already run and already pay for; we are not introducing a new hosting service or its own cost line.
- **Reused, not new, Google project**: this attaches to the Cloud project already in place for our existing YouTube integration — no new vendor account.
- **What this is not**: not a recurring subscription, not a commitment to any paid Google tier, and not a broader mandate to link billing for unrelated future tools without coming back for a separate decision.

Recommendation

We recommend approving the billing account linkage so this monitoring can be built. It closes a real, already-observed gap (5 videos silently blocked) at an expected cost of $0/month, using infrastructure we already operate.

Approval requested: authorize linking a Google Cloud billing account (payment method on file) to our existing Cloud project, specifically to enable Cloud Pub/Sub for this monitoring feature.